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Don't Do An AMERICA

Unlike the US' self-defeating approach, India must understand the enemy, accept he is skilled and realise that the fight against terror begins at home

The Islamist attack in Mumbai was not a mere terrorist event, but an act of war in a campaign against India that resembles the one Al Qaeda has conducted against the US since 1992. The US Government did not take Al Qaeda's war-waging seriously until 9/11, and then it reacted in a profoundly adolescent manner. It continued to do so through the Bush years and probably will maintain that self-defeating approach. Instead of seeing the 9/11 attacks for what they were—part of a deliberate, high-quality, and effective military campaign in response to US foreign policy in the Muslim world—America's political leaders howled about a fanatic, nihilistic enemy ready to kill himself because he hates freedom, liberty, elections, and gender equality, and one that has nothing to do with the Islamic faith. All of this, of course, is bosh, and yet in the American political mind it is still controlling bosh and so the US is losing its war against Al Qaeda and its allies. After Mumbai, India ought to think long and hard before it follows America's post-9/11 path to disaster.

The first step toward adulthood is to accept that the Islamist fighters who attacked in Mumbai and elsewhere were not madmen lashing out indiscriminately to re-establish some sort of Islamic caliphate. The attackers were well-trained, disciplined, highly motivated by their faith and conducted their operation thoroughly and professionally. Their attack was well designed to hurt the Indian economy, being focused on the nation's business capital and major tourist destinations. Before India acts, its leaders ought to accept the mortal threat from an enemy that merits respect as a skilled military adversary.

The second vital but more painful step toward adulthood, and victory, is for Indian leaders to acknowledge—and then tell voters—that India has

been attacked so frequently since 2000 because of what the government does. It is commonplace for historians and military experts to argue that victory can only be achieved after one has understood the enemy's motivation. Acknowledging this is not to empathise, sympathise, or agree with them, it is an effort to shape and implement

THE 26/11 STRIKE (RIGHT) IS AN ACT OF WAR IN A CAMPAIGN AGAINST INDIA THAT PARALLELS THE 9/11 ATTACK ON THE US

